and an oft-quoted Sanskrit verse says: '*Uttaramyatsamudrasyahimadreshachaivadakshinamvarshamtadbharatamnamabharati yatra santatiha* (The country (*varsham*) that lies north of the oceans and south of the snowy mountains is called Bharatam, the descendants of Bharata).'

Our Constitution-makers, realising the historical validity of both India and Bharat, debated at length on which one to adopt, and finally came up with a solution that retained both. Article 1 of the Constitution, which was originally drafted in English, states: 'India, that is Bharat, shall be a Union of states'. The version in Hindi replicates this, but puts Bharat first in the translation: 'Bharat, *arthartha* India, *rajyon ka sanghhoga*'. Does this mean that in English 'India' had primacy, and in Hindi 'Bharat'? Frankly, I doubt it. Language was not the decisive factor (since Hindi is the dominant language primarily only in parts of north India). The truth appears to be that our founding fathers (and mothers) wanted Brand India to be ours (against the protests of Jinnah), and made a compromise to reconcile votaries of either one name or the other. In fact, the Constitution on the whole is a remarkable and commendable exercise of enlightened compromises, to avoid division and retain the unity of the country.

Interestingly, in 2004, when the Mulayam Singh Yadav government in the Uttar Pradesh assemblypassed a resolution to rename India as Bharat, the BJP walked out in protest. Is it now reversing its stand because the opposition alliance is called INDIA? Or is it a symbol of cultural reclamation, at the cost of eliminating another equally valid and indigenous narrative of history? Either way, Ananthamurthy's logic was right: ordinary Indians have long happily accepted both Bharat and India, and also, incidentally, Hindustan. Why reopen this matter? ■

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By **G. ARUNIMA**

INDIA, AS SPOKEN ON ITS EDGES

'INDIA' TAPS INTO A MUCH OLDER STRAND IN MALAYALAM. IT'S ONLY WELL INTO THE 20TH CENTURY THAT 'BHARATHAM' CAME INTO FORMAL USE. EVEN NOW, IT'S NOT QUITE PART OF COMMON SPEECH